

ל כ י ט ח ז ו ה ד ג ב א
ת ש ר ק צ פ ע ס נ מ

About This Story

The story you just saw comes from an ancient Jewish midrash retold by Rabbi Louis Ginzberg in *Legends of the Jews* (1909). Its roots reach back to the Zohar, Bereishit Rabbah, and Otiot de-Rabbi Akiva — some of the oldest texts in Jewish literature.

The central teaching: before God created the world, the twenty-two Hebrew letters descended from God's crown and each one pleaded to be the first letter of creation. Each had a beautiful quality — but also a shadow. Only Bet, the letter of blessing, was chosen.

And Alef — the humble letter who never pushed forward — received the greatest honor of all: the first word of the Ten Commandments begins with Alef.

PRIMARY SOURCES

Bereishit Rabbah 1:10 · sefaria.org

Legends of the Jews 1:1:9 · sefaria.org

Zohar I, 2b-3b · sefaria.org

Sefer Yetzirah 1:1 · sefaria.org

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The Letters Ask to Begin the World

A Living Midrash

The Storyteller

Abraham — Narrator

Our guide through the story. Abraham has seen the stars and wandered far — and now shares the oldest story of all.

The Four Angels

Michael — Angel of Mercy

Calls each letter forward and ensures a fair hearing.

Gabriel — Angel of Strength

Keeps the court in order — with humor.

Uriel — Angel of Light

The wise counselor. Listens carefully to every argument.

Raphael — Angel of Healing

Comforts the rejected letters. The heart of the court.

The Holy Presence

The teacher who portrays Adonai — the divine presence on the throne. Still, attentive, and loving throughout. Rises only once: when Bet is chosen.

The Twenty-Two Letters

ת Tav	ש Shin
ר Resh	ק Kuf
צ Tzade	פ Pe
ע Ayin	ס Samech
נ Nun	מ Mem
ל Lamed	כ Kaf
י Yud	ט Tet
ה Het	ז Zayin
ו Vav & He	ד Dalet
ג Gimel	ב Bet (chosen)
א Alef (honored)	

What Is Happening

Before God created the world, the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet lived on God's crown — engraved in fire.

When the moment of creation arrived, each letter stepped forward and pleaded its case: "Begin the world through me!"

God listened patiently. But each letter had a flaw — a word it began that carried darkness alongside its light.

Then Bet stepped forward. Every day, people say Baruch — "Blessed!" — through Bet. God chose Bet.

And so the Torah begins: Bereshit — "In the beginning."

The Twist

One letter never stepped forward: Alef. It waited quietly, never argued, never pushed. At Mount Sinai, the very first word of the Ten Commandments — Anochi, "I am the Lord your God" — began with Alef. The humble letter received the greatest honor.

Words to Know

- Bereshit:** "In the beginning" — first word of the Torah
- Baruch:** "Blessed" — opens every Jewish blessing
- Alef-Bet:** The Hebrew alphabet — letters God used to create
- Midrash:** An ancient story exploring the meaning of Torah
- Anochi:** "I am" — first word of the Ten Commandments
- Shekhinah:** The divine presence — God's nearness in the world

TWO LESSONS TO TAKE HOME

1. What you are used for matters. Each letter had light and shadow.
2. Humility is rewarded. The one who waits quietly is not forgotten.